

How to Train Your Partner

Jonah Dorman



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A guide to better relationships.

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How to Train Your Partner

A guide to better relationships.

Promise: After this book you can run a relationship like an operator: fix yourself first, read the other person accurately, apply incentives without becoming a manipulator, and keep the thing from rotting.

For: Adults in an intimate relationship who will change their own behavior first.

Not for: Anyone being hit. Anyone whose plan is “make them change while I stay the same.” Anyone hunting a hypnosis script to own a human.

Tone: blunt field manual. Not Hallmark. Not pickup-artist.

Chapter 0

Brief

This is a field manual for intimate relationships. It uses tools from combat leadership, foster-parent training, trauma-informed care, management, and behavior design.

You fix yourself first. Then you communicate so the other person can actually hear it. Then you use incentives, routines, and narrative control to change what happens next — without pretending violence, panic, or “complete me” is love.

Same tools can be used to manipulate. If that is the plan, you are the problem this book is warning the other person about.

Ad Brief

Most relationship books tell you to share your feelings and hope. This one treats the relationship like a system you can run.

If you will change your own behavior first, you get a working sequence: get-out rules, self-repair, communication that lands, questions that expose deal-breakers, and daily operating habits that stop the slow rot.

If you want a script to control someone who does not want you, this is the wrong book.

Jacket

Jonah Dorman is a U.S. Army combat veteran. He trained foster parents, social workers, and child-protection staff in trauma-informed care and positive communication, including service as Regional VP of the Florida Foster Parent Association

and VP of the Pinellas and Pasco associations.

He has led teams from small technical groups to organizations with dozens or hundreds of people, and studied hypnosis, NLP, sales, and performance. The book is what those jobs have in common: humans respond to incentives, stories, and repetition — whether you admit it or not.

Intro

If your partner is hitting you, this book is not the move. Get out. Safe location first. Friends, family, or a domestic violence hotline. Physical violence is not a communication problem and you do not “fix” it from inside the blast radius.

Second: you are not a half looking for a half. If you need a partner to feel like a complete person, that is codependence. Structured interdependence can work. “Save me / complete me” almost never does. A person who cannot be well alone will use the other person as a life-support machine. That is not love. That is a hostage situation with extra holidays.

If either of those is your situation, stop. The rest of this book assumes you are safe enough to stay and whole enough to change yourself first.

Chapter 1

0 Who this book is for

This book is for intimate relationships: dating, living together, married, or trying to get back to any of those without lighting the house on fire.

It does not matter if you are single, on date one, or in year fifty. The sequence is the same. You become a person first. Then you pick. Then you run the system.

This is not the book for your boss, your coworker, your kid, or your vendor. Those are relationships. They get a different book (How to Like People). If you apply partner-training tools to an employee or a child, you are not clever. You are the problem.

Use this book if:

you will change your own behavior first

you want a working sequence, not a feeling

you can leave if the other person is dangerous

Do not use this book if:

you are being physically hurt

your plan is to stay identical while they become convenient

you need someone else to give you a personality

How to find love by finding yourself

Unhealthy codependence starts when you are not living a life and you try to steal one off another person. Low self-worth, no direction, no friends except the partner. They become your mood,

your mirror, and your proof you exist. That is not romance. That is unpaid nursing.

“I just want a family” is the same move wearing a nicer coat. Family is a result. It is not a personality.

You do not prevent that by finding a better half. You prevent it by becoming usable company: interests, standards, a day that still works if they leave. Therapy is fine if you need it. Hobbies are not decoration. They are proof you have a self.

Do not park your life in a holding pattern until someone picks you. People with a life choose better and leave faster when the deal is bad. People with no life cling.

The ten points below are generic on purpose. They are the minimum viable you. Do them before you start “training” anyone.

#1 Get Out

Get out of the bar, get out of your comfort zone, get out of the house.

If the only humans you meet are on a stool or a screen, your dating pool is “whoever sat down.” Comfort feels like standards. It is just a small map.

You do not need a personality transplant. You need repeated contact with people who are not already in your phone. New rooms change who you meet and what you tolerate.

Do this:

Pick one weekly thing that requires shoes and other humans. Class, gym, range, league, volunteer shift. Same day each week. Put it on the calendar.

Once a week, go somewhere you do not already know. New street, new trail, new town, new room. Stay long enough to talk to one person.

After each outing, write one line: who you met, or that you met nobody. That note is the point. It stops the brain from calling a walk “growth.”

Optional later: travel, new sport, a class that scares you. Not week one.

The point: do not replace leaving the house with “reading articles that challenge your assumptions.” That is still the couch.

#2 Experience over Ownership

Buy fewer trophies. Collect proof you have a life.

Stuff is a scoreboard you can point at. Experiences are what you actually talk about, what you get good at, and what makes you decent company. A full closet and an empty week is how people show up to a relationship with nothing but needs.

This is not “never own anything.” A reliable truck, a decent bed, and tools that earn their keep are not the enemy. The enemy is using purchases as a substitute for a self.

Do this:

Before any non-essential buy, write one line: “What would the experience version of this be?” If the experience version is better, do that instead.

Spend one block of time this week on a thing you can remember in five years: a trip, a class, a range day, a hike, cooking something new with another human. Not a package on

the porch.

Once, tell a story about a thing you did, not a thing you own. Notice which one people lean into.

Optional later: declutter, budget line labeled “experiences,” stop flexing purchases. Fine. Not the point.

The point: a partner cannot date your Amazon cart. They date the person who has somewhere to take them and something to talk about that is not a receipt.

#3 Lose the Toxic Friends and Family

Blood and history are not a hall pass. A person who trains you to shrink, apologize for existing, or pick them over your own life will follow you into the next relationship and sit in the passenger seat.

“Toxic” here is not “they disagreed with me.” It is a pattern: they leave you worse, they punish improvement, they need you small. Keep that person close and every partner inherits them. You move toward the five people you spend the most time with. That is not a slogan. It is regression to the mean with extra birthdays.

Do this:

Write two lists. Column A: people who leave you sharper, calmer, more yourself. Column B: people who leave you smaller, broke, ashamed, or late. Names only. No essays.

For anyone in B you cannot fully cut (parent, sibling, coworker), set one hard rule and one consequence. Example: no drunk calls after 9; you hang up. Say it once. Enforce it every time.

Move time from B to A this week. One hang, one call, one invite. Vacancy is how B crawls back.

Optional: a short, calm conversation with a B person. If they treat the boundary as an attack, you already have the answer.

The point: you will date the average of the room you keep. Clean the room before you add a partner to it.

#4 Compliment Yourself Like You Would a Friend

You talk to yourself all day. If that voice is a bully, you will pick partners who agree with it.

Most people can compliment a friend for showing up, finishing a hard thing, or not being a disaster. Then they go home and call themselves lazy, ugly, and behind. That split is not humility. It is training. A partner hears it even when you think you are being quiet.

Do this:

Once a day, say one true specific thing about yourself the way you would say it to a friend. Not “I’m a king.” “I kept the promise I made this morning.”

When you catch a cheap insult (“idiot,” “always late,” “who would want that”), swap it the same way you would stop a friend from saying it about themselves. Out loud if you are alone.

Write down three wins this week. Small counts. Sent the message. Left the house. Did not take the bait.

Optional: the H2LP move — compliment people behind their backs. Same muscle. Different direction.

The point: people with a savage inner narrator date whoever confirms it. Clean up the narrator or you will keep hiring critics.

#5 Love Happens More Than Once

“The one” is a hostage story. It makes the first good thing sacred and every later thing a consolation prize. That belief keeps people in dead relationships and keeps single people on a timer.

Love is not a lottery ticket you either hit at 22 or you lose. People fall in love more than once. They also stay in the wrong one because they think they already used their turn.

Do this:

If you are single: stop treating dates like auditions for a soulmate. Treat them like data. Did you like the person. Did they like you. Would you spend another Tuesday with them.

If you are coupled: write one sentence about what you would still be if this ended. If the answer is “nothing,” that is the codependence problem from the start of this chapter. Fix that before you start “training” anyone.

Name one past love without turning it into a religion or a war crime. Neutral. That is the skill.

Optional: tell one trusted person the “one true love” story you have been dragging. Hear how small it sounds out loud.

The point: if love can only happen once, you will either cling to a corpse or refuse to start. Both are how you stay stuck.

#6 Question Your Self Narrative

You are running an old story like it is law. “I’m not that kind of person.” “I hate that.” “I always ruin it.” Most of those lines are one bad night plus ten years of repetition.

A partner does not date the story. They date the person who keeps obeying it. If the story says you do not dance, do not travel, do not ask, do not leave, do not try, the relationship inherits that cage.

Do this:

Write five sentences that start with “I’m the kind of person who...” Be honest. Ugly is fine.

Circle the one that costs you the most in dating or partnership.

This week, do one small thing that sentence forbids. Not a personality reboot. One rep. Then write what actually happened, not what the story predicted.

Optional: say the old sentence out loud to a friend in Column A and ask if they still believe it about you. Their face is data.

The point: the narrative is not your personality. It is a habit. Test it or it will pick your partner for you.

#7 Overcome Fear

Fear lies in a specific way: it inflates the threat and shrinks you. “If I ask, I die.” “If I leave, I vanish.” “If I look stupid, I am stupid.” Most of that is noise.

Gut is different. Gut is pattern recognition with less speech. Fear screams about imagined futures. Gut usually tags a person or room that already feels wrong. Learn the difference or you will stay in bad relationships for safety and bolt from good ones for

butterflies.

Do this:

When you freeze, write two lines. Line A: what fear says will happen. Line B: what you can actually survive if A is true. If B is survivable, it was fear.

Pick one fear that is blocking a relationship move this week: ask, decline, leave the party, say the true thing. Do the smallest version of it once.

After, write what happened versus what fear promised. Keep the paper. Fear hates records.

Optional: use a Column A person as a spotter. Tell them the move before you do it. Report after. Not a committee. One witness.

The point: fear will pick a partner who never scares you and never grows you. Act while afraid or the liar stays in charge.

#8 Don't Use Someone Else's Mirror

Other people will hand you a reflection if you let them. Parents, exes, a partner in a mood, a feed full of strangers. That image is about their fear, taste, or control. It is not a measurement.

Comparison is the cheap version of the same trap. You borrow their scoreboard, then call yourself behind. A relationship built on that is two people waiting for permission to exist.

Do this:

Catch one sentence this week that starts with "They think I..." or "I'm not as ___ as..." Write who "they" is. If you cannot name a person, it is a ghost. Ignore ghosts.

Make a three-line self-report that does not need a witness: what you did, what you keep, what you will not trade. Read it before you take feedback from a partner or parent.

When someone gives you an identity (“you’re the crazy one,” “you’re the provider,” “you’re lucky anyone stays”), ask: is this a fact I asked for, or a costume they need me in?

Optional: steal skills from a role model. Do not steal their life as a grade.

The point: a partner can describe you. They do not get to issue you. If their mirror is the only one you use, you will date whoever holds it.

#9 Say Yes

Say yes to the thing that scares you and no to the thing that keeps you small.

Those are two different muscles. “Yes” is the ask, the trip, the class, the honest sentence. “No” is the extra shift, the third drink, the family job you do so nobody gets mad. Most people flip them. They say yes to shrinkage and no to anything with a pulse.

Fear from #7 will call every yes “dangerous.” Other people’s mirrors from #8 will call every no “selfish.” Ignore both long enough to run the test.

Do this:

Write two lists for the next seven days. YES: one thing you are avoiding because it might expose you. NO: one thing you keep doing so you stay approved.

Do the yes once. Decline the no once. Do not announce a new personality. Just the two moves.

After each, write the real cost. Not the movie in your head. What actually happened.

Optional: one Column A person as a spotter. Same rule as #7.

The point: a relationship cannot be larger than the life you will agree to live. If you only say yes to comfort, you will pick a partner who needs you quiet.

#9B Practice the Yes Rule

The Yes Rule is simple: when a new opportunity shows up that is legal, moral, and not a threat to your actual life, you say yes. Especially if it puts you in a room with people who are not already in your phone.

This is the H2LP move aimed at a partner-shaped life. You cannot train a relationship from a sealed friend group and a couch. New rooms change your taste. New people change what you think is normal.

What it is not:

Yes to everything. No to crime, no to getting in a car with a stranger who sets off the gut from #7, no to a third obligation that wrecks sleep or money.

Yes to every political rally, every “quick favor,” every person who wants access. That is how you play small with extra steps.

A personality transplant. It is a temporary rule you run on purpose.

The filter, in this order:

Is it legal?

Does it violate a hard value you already have?

Will it take something you cannot spare this week (rent, kids, recovery, a shift you already promised)?

If 1–3 are clean and the only remaining objection is “that’s not me” or “that’s weird” — say yes.

Do this:

Run the rule for a set window. Two weeks is enough to feel it. Tell one Column A person you are running it so you cannot quietly cheat.

Say yes to three things you would normally skip: a new food, a new room, an invite from someone outside your usual circle.

After each yes, write two lines: who was there that is not your usual people, and whether you would do it again. That note is the training.

Optional: travel, a sport, a class that scares you. The cheap version still counts — new restaurant, new group, new street. Skydiving is not required to prove you have a pulse.

Watch the Applebee’s problem. Some people have never sat at a table with silverware. Some people have never cooked. Some people have never been in a room without a title. You do not need to become them. You need to stop living like your current room is the whole species.

The point: the Yes Rule is how you stop marrying the first available person from the only five humans you see. Expand the map, then pick.

#10 Ask for What You Want

Nobody is coming to decode you. Hints are not communication. They are a test the other person did not agree to take.

If you cannot say the thing, you do not get to be angry they missed it. This is true when you are single, dating, living together, or fifty years in. The request changes. The rule does not.

Ask in plain language. “I want Saturday morning without plans.” “I want you to text if you will be late.” “I want to see you again.” “I want this to stop.” Soften the tone if you must. Do not soften the content until it means nothing.

Then watch what you get. The answer is data. Yes. No. Bargain. Silence. A performance of yes with no follow-through. That last one is a no wearing a costume.

Do this:

Write one sentence for the thing you actually want this week. One. If you cannot put it in one sentence, you do not know it yet. Do not ask until you do.

Say it to the person who can grant it. Not a group chat. Not a sigh. Not a meme.

After they answer, write which of the four you got: yes, no, bargain, costume. Respond to that, not to the speech around it.

Optional: if asking feels like dying, that is #7. Do the small version anyway. “Can we leave at ten?” counts.

The point: a relationship cannot be trained, repaired, or enjoyed by a person who will not make a request. The rest of this book assumes you will open your mouth.

That is the end of Chapter 1. Ten points, one job: become someone worth building with before you start operating on someone else.

You now have a self worth taking into a room. That is not the relationship yet. The relationship starts when two nervous systems try to send meaning through air and both of them think they already did it.

Do not run all ten points forever before you talk to anyone. Run them in the background. Chapter 2 is the next skill: make the message land.

Chapter 2 — Communication

Communication is what the listener does. That is the spine of *How to Like People*. H2LP is the general-population manual: smile, names, the 4% rule, how to make a sentence arrive in a stranger or a coworker. This chapter assumes that book. If you cannot get a message across to a human who does not live with you, you will not suddenly get good at it because the human sleeps in your bed.

You do not get credit for sentences that existed in your head. You get credit for what arrived.

The strongest conversations look uneven on a transcript. You talk about 4 percent of the time, stay fully in the room, and steer. That is not silence. That is control of attention. They should feel heard and still know you were leading. H2LP taught that on anybody. Here you point it at one person and keep pointing it until it sticks.

When they talk, you are not waiting to reload. You are collecting. Short question. Play back what you think they meant. Watch whether they relax. That is the test.

Open, Honest Communication

Honesty is matching. What you feel, what you say, and what your face does have to agree. If they do not, you are not communicating. You are training them to ignore the words.

Open is the real request and the real no. Honest is not punishing them for believing you. Do that long enough and the channel becomes: true in, true out. Hint, perform “I’m fine,” smile while furious, and you train the opposite.

Words are the smallest part. Tone and body will confirm you or convict you. Lies leak. Congruence is the job: inside and outside matching hard enough that a tired person can trust it.

Everyone is not you. They cash care on one channel and information on another. Broadcast on yours and you will keep score of gifts they never cashed.

This chapter is the control panel for one relationship. Learn their settings. Learn yours. Run the one that arrives, repeatedly, until the pair of you answers in that language without a meeting. Most people cannot name their own switches. You learn them anyway.

What people actually want — stop projecting the Golden Rule; treat them how they want to be treated.

Love languages — how they cash care: words, service, gifts, time, touch.

Representational systems — how they cash information: pictures, sounds, body.

Communication styles and categories — passive, aggressive, passive-aggressive, assertive; placating, blaming, computing, distracting, leveling. How to be the leveler.

Hierarchy of needs — what layer the fight is actually on.

Six human needs — the drivers under the mood.

Words — whether you are building or poisoning.

What People Want

Why learn these systems at all? Because the rule you were handed is aimed at the wrong person.

The Golden Rule is a decent brake on cruelty. It is a bad targeting system.

“In everything do to others as you would have them do to you.” ~ Matthew 7:12

Same idea, inverted:

“Do not do to others what you do not want them to do to you.” ~ Analects 5.12

Both assume the other human is you with a different face. In traffic that is fine. In a relationship it is how you give speeches to someone who needed a hand on their back, or gifts to someone who needed you to stay and shut up.

The new rule:

Treat others how they want to be treated.

Not how you would want it. Not how your last partner wanted it. Not how a decent person “should” want it. How this person cashes care, information, and repair.

That is why the rest of this chapter exists. Love language, representational system, style, category, needs, words — those are the settings. You learn them so you can send love so it arrives, send information so it arrives, provide what they actually use, and end a fight without guessing.

The onus is on you. Most people cannot name their own switches. They will also lie to themselves about what they want. Two people who built machines said the quiet part:

“If I had asked people what they wanted, they would have said faster horses.” ~ Henry Ford, on the Model T:

“You can’t just ask customers what they want and then try to give that to them. By the time you get it built, they’ll want something new.” ~ Steve Jobs, on the iPhone:

So you do both. Ask once. Then watch what they reach for when they are tired, glad, or hurt. The mouth gives a theory. The week gives the spec. Keep running the spec until the relationship answers in that language without a meeting. That is training. Asking and forgetting is a survey.

Doing unto them as you would have them do unto you feels moral and misses. Learn their system or you will keep delivering the wrong kindness and calling them ungrateful.

Adults Are Just Larger Children

Especially the whiny ones. Under stress a partner will use the same moves a tired kid uses: collapse, blame, perform helpless, or pick a fight for attention. You do not get to parent them. You also do not get to pretend they are a spreadsheet.

Talk to the adult. Watch for the child. Answer the need, not the tantrum. The tools in this chapter are how.

The 5 Love Languages

Love can be sent and never received. That is not a mystery. You delivered it in your language. They feel it in a different one.

Gary Chapman mapped five ways people notice care in The 5 Love Languages. Treat it as a working model, not scripture. Most adults have a primary and a backup. Under stress they get louder about the primary and ruder about the rest.

The trap: people show love the way they want to receive it, then wait to be thanked. You do acts of service all Saturday and

they are still empty because they needed your phone in the other room and your attention on them. You buy the thing. They wanted the sentence. Both of you now have evidence the other does not care. You are both wrong. You used the wrong form.

The five:

Words of Affirmation — they feel cared for when they hear it. Specific beats poetic. “You handled that well” lands. “You’re fine” does not. Empty praise is noise. They will starve next to a quiet provider.

Acts of Service — they feel cared for when a burden comes off their list. The errand, the sink, the thing they would have had to do at 21:00. Doing chores for applause is not the language. Removing the load before they ask is.

Receiving Gifts — they feel cared for when a physical thing proves they were in your head while they were out of the room. Price is rarely the point. Random and specific beats expensive and late. A gift as apology-without-repair is a bribe. They can tell.

Quality Time — they feel cared for when they have you without a split screen. Same couch plus two phones is not time. A walk with the phone away is. They would rather have forty clean minutes than a whole Saturday of you half-there.

Physical Touch — they feel cared for through contact. Hand, shoulder, sex, sitting close enough to count. Touch as a prelude only to getting something is counterfeit. Touch that shows up when nothing is being requested is the language.

How you find theirs

Do not start with a quiz and a personality. Ask one question: “When you actually feel cared for, what happened right before

that?” Then shut up.

Watch the week. What they ask for when they are depleted is the language. What they give you when they are trying is usually their language, not yours. What they complain about in the same fight three times is the empty tank.

You will be wrong once. That is data. Adjust.

How you train it

You speak their primary on purpose, daily, in a size they can notice. Not a campaign. A rep. If theirs is words, you leave one specific sentence, not a speech. If theirs is service, you take one job off the list before they ask. If theirs is gifts, something small that proves memory. If theirs is time, you put the phone down for a defined block. If theirs is touch, you make contact that is not a negotiation.

Then watch the room. Shoulders drop. Fight shortens. They initiate in their language back. That is the install.

Name yours out loud, once, without a trial: “I notice time. When you do the dishes and never sit down with me I still feel ignored.” That is not a complaint. That is the spec. If they start hitting your language, thank the hit in their language. That is how they learn. Respond well to the form you want more of.

Do not keep a spreadsheet they can see. Do not announce “I am speaking your love language now.” Send it so it can be felt. Let them notice.

Mismatch is most of the stupid fights in a house. “You never help” often means “you never touch me.” “You never talk to me” often means “you never stop and stay.” Translate before you go to war.

Representational Systems

Love language is how they receive care. Representational system is how they take in information. You can love them in the right form and still explain the plan in a way their brain throws away.

Richard Bandler and John Grinder, building what became NLP, described three primary ways people code the world: visual, auditory, kinesthetic. Treat it as a working radio, not a religion. Most people can use all three. One is home. Under stress they go home.

Visual

They think in pictures. They understand when they can see it. Language leaks: look, see, show, bright, foggy, “I don’t see how.” They track your face and the room. A wall of talk with no image makes them glaze. Draw it. Point at it. Put the plan on paper. “Here’s what it looks like when this works.”

Auditory

They think in sound. They understand when they hear it said. Listen, tell, rings true, sounds off. They notice your voice more than your slide deck. A grunt plus a chore chart is not communication to them. Say the thing. Repeat the key line. Let them talk it out loud until it clicks. Silence after a decision feels like you hid something.

Kinesthetic

They think in body and gut. They understand when they can feel it or do it. Feel, heavy, solid, rough, “I can’t get a handle on it.” They trust a walk, a demo, a hand on the thing, a night to sleep on it. A perfect speech they cannot inhabit will not move them. Let them do a piece of it. Sit next to them. Give the

decision time to land in the body.

This is not the same as Chapman's Physical Touch. Touch is how some people receive love. Kinesthetic is how some people understand meaning. A kinesthetic partner can need a walk to understand the budget and still not have touch as their love language. Do not collapse the two.

How you find theirs

Listen to the verbs when they are not performing. What they say when they are deciding, complaining, or excited is the tell. "I see what you mean." "That sounds wrong." "It doesn't feel finished." Count those for a week. The pile is the system.

Watch what they ask for. Visual wants the sketch. Auditory wants the conversation. Kinesthetic wants to stand in the space or wait until the body votes. Offer the wrong one and they look stubborn. They are not. The file will not open.

How you train it

Send the same content in their home system first. Then, if needed, add yours as backup.

You want to leave at 8. Visual: "Picture traffic at 8:15 and us still in the driveway." Auditory: "I need to hear we're leaving at 8." Kinesthetic: "If we miss 8 the whole morning feels rushed. Let's get the bags in the car tonight."

Same fact. Three radios. Use theirs.

Match a couple of their words when it matters — repair, plans, sex, money. Do not turn into a parody. One or two matched verbs is pacing. A whole paragraph of "I see you see what I'm seeing" is a trick they will smell.

When they finally take in a hard thing, you got the channel right. Use that channel on the next hard thing. That is the install. You are teaching their nervous system that information from you arrives in a form it can use. Do that long enough and they stop bracing when you start a sentence.

If you are visual and they are kinesthetic, your instinct is to show a list. Their instinct is to feel rushed by the list. Translate or you will fight about character when you are fighting about format.

Information they cannot take in is not communication. Put the message in the system they actually run, then keep putting it there until the house stops losing the plot.

Communication Styles and Categories — How to Be the Leveler

Virginia Satir mapped how families talk when they are scared. You will use two layers. Styles are the stance toward needs: do you state yours, crush theirs, hide, or do both jobs. Categories are the pose in the room right now: peace-keep, attack, go robot, change the subject, or tell the truth.

People have a home style. They change category by the minute. The training target is one combination: assertive + leveling. Everything else in this book gets sloppy if you cannot stand there.

The four styles

Passive — you swallow your need so the room stays quiet. You call it kindness. It is a debt. Later you explode or disappear. They never got a real vote because you never put a real item on the table.

Aggressive — your need is the only one in the building. Volume, speed, contempt. You may get the short-term win. You train them to hide or to fight dirty.

Passive-aggressive — you will not say the no, so the no leaks. Late, “fine,” forgotten chore, joke with teeth. They feel the hit and cannot answer it. That is the point.

Assertive — you say the need in the open and leave room for theirs. “I want to leave at 8. What do you need so that works?” Not a speech. Not a verdict. A clean item.

Assertive is the style. Leveling is how it looks when the whole body agrees with the sentence.

The five categories

Placating — agree, soothe, disappear. “Whatever you want.” Peace bought on your spine. The bill arrives later.

Blaming — the problem is them. Fault-finding as a sport. Keeps you from touching your own part. They will defend instead of solve.

Computing — facts, policy, tone of a manual. Useful for a fuse box. Deadly when they needed a human. They hear “your feelings are off-topic.”

Distracting — joke, phone, side quest, sudden hunger. The subject is the threat. You train the house that hard things do not get finished.

Leveling — same message in words, voice, face, and posture. You name what is happening, including your part. You want a solution that two adults can live with. Satir called this being “on the level.” It is congruence from Chapter 2 wearing work clothes.

You will use the other four. Everyone does. Training is noticing the pose fast and getting back to level before the pose becomes the relationship.

What a leveler actually does

Does not mask the feeling and does not drown the room in it.

States the problem as a problem, not as a character judgment.

Can say “I am angry” without becoming the anger.

Leaves their partner a way to stay in the conversation.

Matches. If the mouth says “I’m fine” and the jaw is granite, that is not leveling. That is a lie their body already told.

Skip the poster attributes about “positive mind images.” The working list is shorter: look for a fix, say the real motive, keep your values in the sentence, change tactics when the current one fails, get in rapport before you push. That is enough.

Incongruence

Thought and feeling point one way. Words and body point another. Fake smile. Soft voice over a threat. “I said I wasn’t mad.” People do not need a degree to feel that. They just stop trusting the channel. Satir’s categories are useful because each one is a favorite way to be incongruent: placater smiles, blamer swells, computer goes flat, distracter leaves the scene. The leveler is the one whose signals agree.

How you find the weather

Watch what they do when a need is on the table.

Swallow it → passive / placate.

Run you over → aggressive / blame.

Agree and sabotage → passive-aggressive.

Cite policy while you are crying → compute.

Change the subject → distract.

Name the thing and stay → level.

Do the same audit on you. You cannot level a fight you are secretly placating.

How you train it

You become the leveler first. You do not announce Satir at dinner.

When they placate: do not take the fake yes. “That sounded like a whatever. I need a real answer. Yes, no, or not now.”

When they blame: do not try the case. “I’m willing to look at my part. I’m not willing to be the whole problem. Here’s mine. What’s yours?”

When they compute: join the facts for one beat, then bring the human back. “The numbers are right. I also need us to talk about how this feels, or we will just rerun it.”

When they distract: name the exit. “We left the subject. I need ten more minutes on this, then we can drop it.”

When you want to go passive-aggressive: say the no out loud instead. That single swap is half the book.

Your reps: one clean assertive sentence a day in a real moment. Need plus room for theirs. Body allowed to match. If you smile through it, you trained the wrong thing.

When they level back even once — they stay, they name their piece, they look for a fix — respond well. Do not punish the first honest sentence because it was late. That is how you teach the house which pose works.

Conflict is not the enemy. The pose is. Get both of you back on the level or you will keep solving the wrong fight with the wrong face.

The Four Horsemen

John Gottman watched couples fight for decades and named four moves that predict a split. He called them the Four Horsemen. You already have the antidotes in this book. Here are the names so you can see them when they walk in.

Criticism — the person, not the act. “You never help.” “What’s wrong with you?” A complaint is “the dishes are still in the sink.” Criticism is a verdict on their character. Words chapter: always, never, worthless, crazy. Ban those.

Contempt — the worst of the four. Eye-roll, sneer, mockery, “you’re pathetic.” You are above them. Gottman called this the single strongest predictor. It is a negative that writes deep. Leveling cannot live in the same room as contempt.

Defensiveness — “Yes, but.” Counter-attack. Innocent victim. Their point never lands because you are already on trial. Satir’s blamer and computer both hide here.

Stonewalling — the body leaves. Silence, phone, walk-out mid-sentence. Usually flooding, not strategy. To the other person it still reads as “you do not matter.”

You do not need a new system. You already have it.

Criticism → a clean complaint plus assertive leveling. Need on the table. Room for theirs.

Contempt → out. Appreciation and specific credit from Words and unprompted compliments.

Defensiveness → take your piece. “Here’s mine. What’s yours?”

Stonewalling → the pause below, then return. Not a disappearing act.

Name the horseman in your own head. Get back to level. Do not announce Gottman at dinner.

Hierarchy of Needs

Abraham Maslow stacked human needs in a pyramid: body, safety, belonging, esteem, then becoming. It is not a law of physics. It is a diagnostic. People do not always climb in order. They do drop a level when something essential breaks, and they get stupid about everything above it.

The relationship use is simple. Most fights are sold as personality. A lot of them are a lower layer yelling through a higher sentence.

The five, as you will actually meet them:

Physiological — food, sleep, water, pain, air, a body that works. A partner who has not eaten or slept is not “being difficult.” They are an animal. Do not run a values seminar at 23:00 on an empty stomach.

Safety — lock on the door, money that clears, health that is not a cliff, knowing they will not get hit or ambushed. If this layer

is cracked, love language lectures bounce. They are scanning for threat. Your job is to make the room predictable before you ask for intimacy.

Love and belonging — “are we a we.” Friendship, family, the pair. This is the layer people think every fight is about. Sometimes it is. Sometimes it is safety wearing a romance costume.

Esteem — respect, competence, status in the other person’s eyes. “You don’t value me” is often this, not belonging. They still want to be yours. They do not want to be small.

Self-actualization — growth, craft, becoming. Real, and last. You do not coach someone’s purpose while the rent and the marriage are on fire. You also do not mock it once the lower layers work. A partner with no room to become will eventually resent the house that keeps them useful.

Maslow said lower needs grab the wheel until they are stable enough. That is the training insight. You do not have to agree with the whole pyramid to use that.

How you find the layer

Ask what would make this fight evaporate by morning.

Food and sleep → body.

Money, health, violence, chaos → safety.

“Do you even want me” → belonging.

“You talk to me like I’m stupid” → esteem.

“I can’t be myself here” → actualization.

If they are snapping about dishes and they worked a double and skipped dinner, you are not in a respect war. You are in a blood-sugar war. Feed the layer that is actually empty.

How you train it

Name the layer before you name the character. Out loud, short. “This isn’t about the tone. You’re wiped and we haven’t eaten.” Or: “This isn’t about the weekend. You’re scared about the account.” Wrong layer solutions make you look cruel and them look crazy.

Stabilize down before you demand up. You will not get better sex talks out of someone who does not feel safe in the house. You will not get a growth plan out of someone who thinks they are about to be left. Fix the floor they are standing on, then climb.

When they come at you from a high layer (“you never support my goals”) and you can see a low one smoking, do both in order. First the floor: sleep, money, safety, “we are not done.” Then the high request. Skip the floor and they will hear “your dream can wait” as “you can wait.”

Watch your own drop. Hungry you is a blamer. Scared you is a computer or a passive-aggressive. That is Satir plus Maslow in the same kitchen. Get the layer up one step before you try to level.

Do not weaponize the pyramid. “You’re not self-actualized” is not a point. It is contempt. Use it to aim care and timing, not to grade them.

Talk to the need that is empty, not the story stacked on top of it. Wrong layer, right speech, still a miss.

The Six Human Needs

Tony Robbins' list is not a replacement for Maslow. Maslow tells you which floor is collapsing. This list tells you which drivers are steering the person once they can stand. Everybody has all six. Each person ranks two or three as non-negotiable and will torch a room to feed them.

The six:

Certainty — need to know what happens next. Routine, money that behaves, “we are okay.” Fed well, it is calm. Fed ugly, it is control, interrogation, no trips, no change, a partner treated like a fire hazard.

Variety — need for new. Surprise, travel, a fight, a project, a different restaurant. Fed well, it is play. Fed ugly, it is chaos, affairs, picking fights to feel alive, boredom dressed up as “we’ve grown apart.”

Significance — need to matter, to be the one. Competence, status, “you’d notice if I were gone.” Fed well, it is pride in the work and in the pair. Fed ugly, it is scorekeeping, jealousy, volume, needing an audience.

Love and connection — need to be with, not just approved of. Belonging with this person. Fed well, it is warmth. Fed ugly, it is cling, testing, “if you loved me you would.”

Growth — need to be better than last year. Skill, mind, body, craft. Fed well, it pulls the relationship forward. Fed ugly, it is a partner used as a project, or a partner abandoned for the course, the gym, the next self.

Contribution — need to give to something outside the pair. Kids, unit, craft, community. Fed well, it makes the house mean

more than two appetites. Fed ugly, it is martyrdom, or a cause that always outranks the person at the table.

The collisions you will actually live

Certainty vs variety is the classic couple fight. One wants the same Friday. One wants a pulse. Neither is broken. Unnamed, it becomes “you’re boring” vs “you’re unstable.”

Significance vs love is the other one. They got praised and still felt alone, or they got held and still felt small. You sent the wrong need and called it love.

Growth without connection turns the house into a finishing school. Connection without growth turns it into a padded cell.

How you find theirs

Watch what they will pay for. Time, money, peace, dignity — what they spend to get a feeling is the need.

They cancel plans to keep the routine → certainty.

They pick a fight after a quiet month → variety.

They need the last word or the credit → significance.

They go raw when you are distant → connection.

They get depressed when life is only maintenance → growth.

They light up when the thing helps someone else → contribution.

Ask once, if you want: “When you feel like yourself, what need just got fed?” Then watch the week anyway. Mouth is theory. Behavior is spec.

How you train it

Feed their top two on purpose in a clean way so they stop feeding them in a dirty way.

High certainty: tell them the plan. Keep the promise. Give warning before you change the Friday.

High variety: put novelty on the calendar so they do not have to smash the furniture to feel a spark.

High significance: specific credit, in front of someone if that is their radio. Do not treat them as staff.

High connection: unsplit attention. Not a gift. Presence.

High growth: room and respect for the thing they are becoming.

High contribution: a place their giving can land that is not only you.

Name yours the same way, once. “I need certainty on money and connection at night. If those are empty I get ugly.” That is a spec, not a threat.

When they meet your need cleanly, respond well in their language and to their need. That is the install. They learn which move works. You learn to stop starving them and then diagnosing their character.

Do not moralize the need. Certainty is not cowardice. Variety is not infidelity. Significance is not narcissism until it is. Starved people use ugly tools. Feed the need; the tool often gets quieter.

You are not fighting a mood. You are looking at an empty driver. Fill the real one or they will fill it with something you hate.

Words

Words do not evaporate. In a long relationship they stick on file. A sentence from year two will come back in year nine, usually late at night, usually accurate enough to hurt. You do not get to say “that was a long time ago” if you never took it off the record.

Later chapters are how you work that file. You cannot unsay the sentence. You can overwrite it: repair the line, change the story you both tell about that night, and stop feeding the archive new ammunition. Chapter 8 is changing the past. Chapter 10 is the daily reps that keep the new record in place. Until then, treat every sharp sentence as something you may have to retrieve.

“The words you choose to use and the thoughts you choose to think ultimately shape your destiny.” ~ Robin Sharma

“The words of others can be the chains that bind us, or the keys that set you free. Be careful who you listen to, and be mindful of the words you choose to let into your mind and heart.” ~ author unknown

“Be careful of your thoughts, for your thoughts become your words. Be careful of your words, for your words become your actions. Be careful of your actions, for your actions become your habits. Be careful of your habits, for your habits become your character. Be careful of your character, for your character becomes your destiny.” ~ often attributed to Frank Outlaw; commonly (and sloppily) called a Chinese proverb

“Think twice before you speak, because your words and influence will plant the seed of either success or failure in the mind of another.” ~ Napoleon Hill

“Words are singularly the most powerful force available to humanity. You can choose to use this force constructively with words of encouragement, or destructively using words of despair. Words have energy and power with the ability to help, to heal, to hinder, to hurt, to harm, to humiliate and to humble.” ~ Yehuda Berg, Kabbalah teacher and author

The Monster Study

In 1939 Wendell Johnson’s team at the University of Iowa ran what later got called the Monster Study. Twenty-two orphans. Some already stuttered. Some did not. One group got praise for their speech. The other got criticism: you are doing this wrong, do not speak unless you can do it right.

The criticized children got worse. Some who had been fine started to stumble. Confidence dropped. The stain lasted into adulthood for some of them. The study was a moral failure. It is also a clean demonstration: labels from a trusted mouth install. You do not need a lab to do this at home. You need a kitchen and a year.

Self-talk does the same job from the inside. If you run “I always ruin it” long enough, you will perform it. If you run “they never listen” long enough, you will stop speaking in a way anyone could hear. The Monster Study is the external version. Chapter 1’s inner narrator is the internal one. A partner lives in both.

Better a slip with the foot than with the tongue

“Better slip with foot than tongue” is credited to Benjamin Franklin. Stumble in the hallway and you look clumsy. Stumble with a sentence and you may still be paying in a decade.

*“The tongue has the power of life and death.” ~ Proverbs
18:21*

A kick in the shin ends. “You are just like your mother.” “I should have left.” “You’re lucky I stay.” Those sit in the file. Anyone who has lasted more than a couple of years already knows the courtroom move: old quotes, produced on demand, still sharp. That is not them being petty. That is you having trained the archive.

Three lessons worth keeping:

Words outlast the mood that launched them. Anger ends. The recording does not.

It is cheaper to look clumsy than to say the thing you cannot unsay. Walk away. Break a glass. Do not name them as the enemy.

Self-control here is not manners. It is operational security for the relationship. The tongue wants the last word. The last word is often the one that gets quoted back.

Screens made this worse. Text and social have no tone and a perfect memory. A nasty line in a thread is Franklin’s slip with a backup drive.

How you train it

Stop using words as weapons you plan to apologize for later. “I was just mad” does not delete the install. If it came out of your mouth, it is in the building.

Ban the lazy killers in conflict: always, never, worthless, crazy, “you’re just like X,” threats to leave used as volume knobs. You can be furious without issuing a verdict on their soul.

When you do slip — and you will — repair the sentence, not just the feeling. “I said you never help. That was false. I was angry about tonight. I do not get to write you off.” Specific. No “sorry you felt that way.” The archive needs a new entry that contradicts the old one, repeated, or the old one stays canon.

Put good language in on purpose the same way you put poison in by accident. Specific credit. In front of someone if their love language is words. Behind their back if you want it to travel. H2LP already told you compliments behind the back work. They work harder at home because home is where the Monster Study runs for years.

Listen to what you allow in. If a parent, friend, or feed keeps handing you a rotten name for your partner, that name will come out of your mouth during a fight. You chose the input.

You are always installing. Praise installs ability. Contempt installs doubt. An old insult will return in the next serious fight unless you overwrite it on purpose. Speak like someone who knows there will be a transcript.

Chapter 3 : Questions | Separate Document

Chapter 4 — Preventing Trauma Bonds

A trauma bond is attachment glued by fear plus intermittent reward. Hot, cold, sorry, explosion, honeymoon. The nervous system reads that as importance. It is not love. It is a slot machine with teeth.

This chapter stays short on purpose. You do not need a trauma textbook to see the setup. You need two facts: childhood load raises the odds you will call chaos “home,” and a big gap in that load between two people often shows up as one person chasing and the other controlling.

ACE score

The Adverse Childhood Experiences questionnaire comes from the CDC–Kaiser work led by Vincent Felitti and Robert Anda. Ten yes/no items before age 18. One point each. It is a risk screen, not a diagnosis and not a life sentence.

For each “yes,” add 1. The total is your ACE score.

BEFORE YOUR 18TH BIRTHDAY:

Did a parent or other adult in the household often or very often... a) Swear at you, insult you, put you down, or humiliate you? or b) Act in a way that made you afraid that you might be physically hurt?

Did a parent or other adult in the household often or very often... a) Push, grab, slap, or throw something at you? or b) Ever hit you so hard that you had marks or were injured?

Did an adult or person at least 5 years older than you ever...
a) Touch or fondle you or have you touch their body in a sexual way? or b) Attempt or actually have oral, anal, or vaginal intercourse with you?

Did you often or very often feel that... a) No one in your family loved you or thought you were important or special? or b) Your family didn't look out for each other, feel close to each other, or support each other?

Did you often or very often feel that... a) You didn't have enough to eat, had to wear dirty clothes, and had no one to protect you? or b) Your parents were too drunk or high to take care of you or take you to the doctor if you needed it?

Were your parents ever separated or divorced?

Was your parent/caregiver: a) Often or very often pushed, grabbed, slapped, or had something thrown at them? or b) Sometimes, often, or very often kicked, bitten, hit with a fist, or hit with something hard? or c) Ever repeatedly hit over at least a few minutes or threatened with a gun or knife?

Did you live with anyone who was a problem drinker or alcoholic, or who used street drugs?

Was a household member depressed or mentally ill, or did a household member attempt suicide?

Did a household member go to prison?

Higher scores track with higher risk of depression, addiction, heart disease, and some cancers. Very high scores can lock a body in threat mode for years. That chronic alarm is one path to the immune system attacking the host. Correlation, not a curse. The score says "watch this," not "you are broken."

Drastic ACE gaps show up a lot in abusive and codependent pairs. One person learned love as walking on glass. The other learned love as being obeyed. Together they can build a bond that feels like fate and runs like a trap.

If the Intro's violence test already fired, stop. This chapter is not how you repair a beating. It is how you notice why intensity feels like home before Chapters 6–10 teach incentives. Those tools will install whatever you aim them at. Aim them at a trauma bond and you will get a stronger one.

The point: count the load. Do not confuse a high-ACE pull toward chaos with chemistry. If the relationship only works when someone is scared or sorry, it is not a language problem. It is this.

Chapter 5 — Neurobiology

You may skip to Chapter 9 or 10. This chapter is the wiring diagram, not a drill. Later you will use it: novelty, fear, touch, and routines all push different levers. If you only want the levers, skip. If you want to stop confusing a chemical spike with love, stay.

Neurobiology here means the chemicals that change what a partner feels like in the next twenty minutes. Not a degree. A map.

Adrenaline

Stress and fear. Heart up, ready to run or hit. Shared danger feels like a bond because the body is loud. A fight can give the same hit as a roller coaster. That is why some couples pick a war when the week was quiet.

Noradrenaline (norepinephrine)

Cousin of adrenaline. Focus plus alarm. Good for a hard task together. Bad as the house default. A relationship that only feels “real” when someone is activated is running this lever.

Dopamine

Reward and chase. New, almost, maybe. Dating is a dopamine factory. So is intermittent affection. So is a trauma bond. The hit is the pursuit and the unpredictability, not the peace. If it only feels alive when they pull away, that is dopamine, not proof.

Oxytocin

Touch, trust, “we.” Skin, sex, holding a crying person you actually care about. It lowers the guard. That is why touch after a

fight can glue the fight in place if you never fix the thing. Bond first, repair second, or you train: explode, then cuddle, then explode.

Endorphins

Pain down, glow up. Effort, sex, laugh, sometimes spice. Shared hard physical things work because the body pays you for finishing.

Serotonin

Mood, sleep, “the floor is stable.” Light, movement, not living in a hole. Low serotonin makes every text a verdict. Do not diagnose a character problem at 1 a.m. in winter in a body that has not seen sun or a workout.

GABA

The brake. Quiets alarm. Movement, breath work, some music. Alcohol also leans on GABA, which is why it feels like peace and then steals tomorrow. Do not use a bottle as the couple’s only downshift.

Glutamate

The gas. Learning, memory, “this matters, store it.” Strong scenes write deeper — good ones and ugly ones. That is why the year-two insult is still on file. The brain saved it on purpose.

You do not need to memorize doses. You need the pairings:

Quiet week + sudden fight = adrenaline / dopamine looking for a spike.

Makeup sex with no repair = oxytocin sealing the wrong lesson.

New scary thing done together = adrenaline + dopamine + then oxytocin if you land it as a team. That is the good version. Chapter 9–10 use it.

Hot-cold partner = dopamine schedule. Chapter 4 already named it.

A feeling is not a verdict. It is often a chemical you just invited. Learn which lever you pulled before you call it destiny.

Orgasms and Addictions

Why the chemicals matter here: orgasm and addiction run on overlapping rails. Dopamine for the chase and the hit. Oxytocin for the glue after. Endorphins for the glow and the pain-down. Glutamate for “write this in memory.” That is why sex can bind a pair and why a fight, a bottle, a feed, or an affair can steal the same machinery.

Orgasm is not a moral event. It is a stack. Dopamine says worth chasing. Oxytocin says worth keeping. Endorphins say the body can stand down. Done with a person you are building with, that stack is a feature. Done as the only repair after cruelty, it is how you install a trauma bond with better lighting.

Addiction is the same reward system with the governor ripped out. A drug dump of dopamine trains the brain to stop bothering with the small, legal hits — a walk, a laugh, a normal Tuesday. Glutamate helps lock the cue: this place, this fight, this late-night loop. GABA and serotonin are the mood floor. Smash them and every ordinary hour feels like withdrawal.

You care because a relationship can become the drug or compete with one. Intermittent affection is a dopamine schedule. Makeup sex is oxytocin on a crime scene. Porn, affairs, rage, and

work-until-you-drop all bid for the same levers. If you do not know the levers, you will call the spike “passion” and the crash “we’ve changed.”

Simplifying the data

Adrenaline — scare, thrill, stress, fight-or-flight.

Noradrenaline — same family: alarm plus focus.

Dopamine — pleasure, chase, reward, “again.” New and scary both pull it.

Oxytocin — touch, trust, we. The glue.

GABA — brake. Calm. Movement, breath, some music. Alcohol leans on this and then steals the next day.

Glutamate — write it down. Learning and memory. Strong scenes stick.

Endorphins — pain down, glow up. Effort, sex, laugh.

Serotonin — mood floor, sleep, not everything is a verdict.

Menu of what actually moves the stack

Scary or new things. Shared thrill. Physical touch. Sex. Hard physical effort. Sun. Music. Laughing. Meditation or breath work. Spicy food if you like it. Alcohol if you want a fake brake and a real bill.

That list is not a lifestyle brand. It is the raw material for the next section. You are going to pick from it on purpose with one person, so the pair gets the good stack — novelty, a little fear, touch, landing — without needing a crisis to feel alive.

Orgasm and addiction prove the chemicals are not theory. They already run your house. Next you use them instead of getting used by them.

Moves that use the chemistry

You already have the card. Now run it with one person. Goal: shared spike, then shared landing. Spike without landing is a fight or an affair. Landing without spike is a roommate.

Move 1 — New and slightly scary, together

First date or year twelve. Same move. Do something neither of you has on autopilot. Body involved. Outside if you can. Then stop and land: touch, food, laugh, no performance review of how it went.

Scary enough that the heart notices. Not so scary that one of you is actually unsafe. A hard hike, cold water, a class you might look stupid in, a night drive to a place you do not know. Skydiving is optional theater. Novelty plus a little fear is the dose.

What it does: adrenaline and noradrenaline make it loud. Dopamine pays you for finishing. Glutamate files it. If you then touch and laugh, oxytocin and endorphins tell the brain “we survived this as a we.” That is the moral of the research, in one chain. Do not do the spike and then check your phone in the car.

Recipe, when you want the whole stack in a day: new + a bit scary + moving + daylight. Land with touch and a laugh. Music if it helps. Spicy food if you both like it. Candlelight after, not instead. Alcohol is not the move. It fakes the brake.

Do not turn every Saturday into an obstacle course. One real one beats six performances. Early love already dumps dopamine.

Long love has to schedule a small version of new or the pair starts manufacturing crises to feel the same hit.

Move 2 — Happiness, gratitude, positive words

Dopamine is not only cliffs and first dates. It also pays specific good language and noticed wins. Helen Fisher's work on early love is the loud version: chase, infatuation, can't think. Long love still needs a smaller drip or the brain goes looking.

If you have nothing useful to say, find one true specific compliment and say it. Not "you're fine." Not a speech. The thing they did. H2LP already told you words install. Here they also refill a tank you spent two chapters learning to see.

Gratitude out loud is not manners. It is how you keep dopamine from deciding the relationship is boring because you stopped marking what works. The caution is the same as any reward system: if praise is the only hit and it becomes rare, you get tolerance and scorekeeping. Mean it. Repeat it. Do not use it as a remote control.

Move 3 — Touch

Skin is the oxytocin lever. Hand, hug, sit close, sex if that is the language. Talk while touching and the conversation often changes because the guard drops.

When you are not touching them, that stack is not running. Distance is quiet. Some people read quiet as safety. Some read it as withdrawal. If touch has been the main glue, absence will feel like a drug missing. That is the caution: you can make someone hungry for a state that only exists when you are in the room. Use that to build a pair, not a leash. If they only feel loved while in contact and fall apart the hour you leave, you did not invent

romance. You invented dependence. Pair touch with words, time, and a life that still works when you are at work.

Makeup touch with no repair still files the fight as the price of glue. Spike, land, then fix the thing, or you trained Chapter 4 by accident.

Move 4 — Feeling safe, comfortable, cared for

Moves 1–3 are the spark. This is the floor. Without it the spark is just another alarm.

Safe is Maslow’s second layer and Robbins’ certainty sitting in the same chair. The body will not cash novelty, words, or touch as love if it is still scanning for threat. Heart rate from a hike is useful. Heart rate from “are they going to explode” is Chapter 4.

Comfort is not boredom. Comfort is: I know how this house works. The plan was kept. The door is locked. The voice does not turn into a verdict without warning. Sleep is possible. Food happens. Nobody is using silence as a weapon today.

Cared for is the proof that lands in their language. Time, service, words, gift, touch — pick the one they actually feel. Safety without that proof is a motel. Proof without safety is a high that requires recovery.

What it does in the stack: serotonin and GABA want a stable floor. Oxytocin sticks when the room is not a crime scene. Dopamine from Move 1 stays “we did a thing” instead of “we almost died at home.”

How you train it:

Predictable beats grand. Say when you will be back. Be back. If you cannot, send the message before the hour is late, not after

the story has started in their head.

Stop using withdrawal as a teaching tool. Disappearing to make them hungry is a dopamine trick. It taxes safety to buy chase.

After a spike — fight or adventure — land. Water, food, warmth, a hand, a normal sentence. The nervous system needs an off-ramp or it files the whole day as danger.

Watch ACE gaps here. A high-load partner may need more notice, more follow-through, more “we are not done” before they can enjoy Move 1. That is not them being high-maintenance. That is a nervous system that learned love as glass.

If they only feel alive when they are unsafe, do not add more plot. Add floor. If they only feel safe when nothing ever happens, add one small Move 1 on top of a week that already worked. Spark on a floor. Not spark instead of a floor.

A pair that cannot rest cannot bond. Make the ordinary hours trustworthy or the chemistry chapter is just how you get better at lighting fires.

Part 4 — How to Train Your Partner

Everything in this part can improve how long a relationship lasts and how it feels to live in. The same tools can be used to shrink someone. You already saw that warning in the Brief. Physical violence is out. A bond built on fear plus the occasional kindness is out. What remains is incentive.

People do more of what is followed by something they want. They do less of what is followed by something they do not want. Fear is an incentive. Happiness is an incentive. You are already using both, whether you meant to or not.

Chapter 6 — Understanding Incentive; Relationship Math

The math

Negative words or interactions = -2 or more. At least twice as strong. They last longer.

Positive words or interactions = $+1$ or less. At most half as strong. They fade faster.

If you need a list of nice lines and ugly lines, you are reading the wrong book.

This is not a game score. It is how memory works. The mind holds onto threat harder than it holds onto comfort. One sharp comment at night can outweigh a decent day. Three kind comments do not automatically cancel “you always.” They barely chip it. Plan accordingly.

Picture a camping trip. Weather turns. You pack out, trip, bruise a knee, land in the mud. The trees and the good hours were real. What you will tell for years is the fall. The worse the injury, the clearer the story. The pleasant parts fade first.

Now picture a good day with your partner. Time together. Easy. That evening they criticize you. Maybe they are even right. It still stings. Tomorrow, the criticism is what your body remembers as “what this person is like.” The good afternoon becomes background.

That is the same pattern as the mud. Negative moments hit harder and stay longer. That runs from a real wound down to a forgotten chore. Your ancestors remembered the animal that took a hand. Your partner may remember the dishes with more heat than the memory deserves. The hardware does not scale fairly. It scales for survival.

Positive moments still matter. A good meal, a laugh, a day that worked. They just do not write as deeply. You cannot wash out a cruel sentence with one bouquet. You stop adding the cheap negatives, you add the positives on purpose, and later you go back and correct the record. That last part is Chapter 8. Until then, assume the ugly line is still sitting there.

Violence is an end, not an incentive

If someone is hitting you, this chapter does not apply. Leave. Safe place. Friends, family, or a domestic violence hotline. The Intro already said this. Pain is not a teaching tool here. It is the end of the project called “relationship.”

What incentives are

An incentive is anything that makes a behavior more likely or less likely to happen again.

A thank-you after they take the trash out makes taking the trash out more likely tomorrow. A sigh and a speech makes it less likely, or makes it happen with a slam. The incentive is not the speech you meant. It is whatever actually followed the behavior.

It can be pleasant or unpleasant. It can happen now or later. It can be real or only expected. The brain does not need your permission. If a fight reliably follows honesty, honesty becomes rare. If warmth reliably follows a small effort, the effort shows up more.

Pleasant incentives offer something they want: warmth, help, credit, time, quiet, a problem lifted.

Unpleasant incentives offer something they do not want: coldness, a lost Saturday, a look that means the room just changed.

Both change behavior. Fear gets fast results. It also gets hiding, lying, and a house that cannot rest. Happiness gets slower change and a house that can sleep. You will use both in real life. Which one you lean on decides what you are living in a year from now.

Incentives run modern life

Steven Levitt and Stephen Dubner put it simply in *Freakonomics*: incentives are the cornerstone of modern life. People move toward what they gain and away from what they lose, including when they claim they are above that.

Their example still works. Teachers in Chicago were caught cheating on standardized tests after bonuses were tied to scores.

That was not a riddle about character. It was a reward standing in the wrong place.

They also split incentives into pull and push. Pull invites — a bonus, a promotion, a reason to move toward something. Push deters — a fine, a penalty, a reason to back away. In a kitchen the pull is the +1 that actually lands for that person. The push is the -2 you will hear quoted years later.

Freakonomics treats the hidden side as the part that matters. In a fight the hidden side is rarely the dishes. It is which behavior just got paid and which one just cost. You are already running that system. This part of the book is how you run it on purpose.

Operant and classical conditioning

B.F. Skinner described operant conditioning: you do something, something follows, and that result makes you more likely or less likely to do it again.

“The consequences of one’s behavior determine one’s future behavior.” ~ B.F. Skinner

If a child gets a toy after cleaning the room, cleaning the room starts to happen more. If doing the dishes is followed by warmth instead of a speech, the dishes start to happen more. The behavior is chosen. The result teaches.

That is most of what people mean by “training.” You are not hypnotizing anyone. You are being consistent and intentional about what follows what.

Ivan Pavlov described classical conditioning: two things keep showing up together until one of them alone is enough. Bell, then food. After enough pairings, the bell is enough. Our Invocation training uses this on purpose with SmileBell™ a system that

allows you to genuinely smile on command. The body learns the pairing whether you planned a lesson or not.

In a relationship the “bell” is often the person. If they are usually critical, walking into the room can produce tightness before a word is said. The partner has become the signal. If they are usually kind, walking into the room can produce ease before a word is said. Same mechanism. Different pairing.

You did not decide to feel that. Classical conditioning is mostly automatic. Operant is the part where someone chooses an action because of what happened last time.

Classical also tends to take hold faster. The body links signal and feeling without a meeting. Operant takes longer because the person has to do the behavior, get the result, and do it enough times for the pattern to stick.

You will use both. Operant is how you make a useful habit more common: the effort happens, something decent follows. Classical is how the whole relationship starts to feel like safety or like dread when the car pulls in. If the feeling at the door is already bad, no amount of clever rewards that night will fully catch up. You have been ringing the wrong bell for months or years.

Negative has more power than positive

People run from fear harder than they walk toward happiness. That is not a character flaw. That is the design.

Picture a cave, or a garden — somewhere that means you can stop scanning for a minute. Outside it there is a predator. There are also berries and flowers. You will sprint from the teeth. You will not sprint toward the fruit with the same legs. One mistake

with the predator and the story ends. One slow afternoon with the berries and you are not hungry.

Fear is the predator. It is loud and now. Heart rate up, muscles ready, senses sharp. Adrenaline and its cousins are doing their job: get back to the cave. Chapter 5 already named those chemicals. They are not subtle. They do not wait for a meeting.

Happiness is the berries. Well-being, ease, a good hour. Worth walking toward. Not usually worth a sprint. “I’ll pick those later” survives. “There are teeth behind me” does not wait.

That is why the math in this chapter is -2 against $+1$. The cut, the slam, the look that means the room changed — those are teeth. They write deeper than the compliment you meant to give. A partner will work harder to get out of your anger than they will work to reach your warmth, unless the warmth is unusually clear and unusually consistent.

Use that fact. Do not worship it. A house run on teeth will get people back to the cave fast. It will also get hiding, lying, and a flinch when the car pulls in. That is classical conditioning with a bad bell. A house that wants to last still respects why the sprint exists — which is why you stop throwing cheap teeth into the week — and then it puts most of its weight on the slower thing: make the garden reliable enough that walking toward it feels safe.

The cave keeps you alive. The garden is why you wanted to live there.

Positive redirection

Fear gets people back to the cave. Redirection is how you point them at the garden without adding another set of teeth.

The idea comes from good teaching and good parenting. A child is headed toward the thing you do not want. Instead of saying no, you give them a better thing to do, and you make that thing easier to succeed at. Adults run on the same wiring. They just hate being spoken to like children, so you skip the lecture and move the path.

Positive redirection means this: when the behavior or the mood is going somewhere useless, you turn attention toward a useful next step instead of pouring more criticism on the current one.

If they are spiraling about the mess, you do not add a speech about character. “Let’s start with the sink. I’ll take the trash.”

If they are picking a fight because the day was empty, you do not win the fight. “Come walk with me. We can finish this after we eat.”

If you are rehearsing everything they did wrong, you do not let that become the evening. You name one thing that would actually improve the next hour and do that.

The person still learns. They learn without the –2 that sticks for years. Correction that feels like support is easier to take than correction that feels like a verdict. That is not softness. That is how you get the behavior to change and still have someone who will talk to you tomorrow.

It also starves the old behavior. Attention is a result. If the only way to get you present is a problem, you will get more problems. If useful action gets you present, useful action starts to show up.

People are wired to look for the saber-tooth. A problem reads as a threat. Finding it feels like survival, so the eye goes there first and stays there. Pointing at the teeth does not require much risk. Walking out to pick berries does. So relationships fill with people who are excellent at naming danger and slow to take a step. Redirection is the habit of asking, out loud if needed, “What would make this better in the next twenty minutes?” Then you go there.

Use it with a partner. Use it with a team. Use it on yourself. The last one matters. If your inner narrator only runs inspections, you will bring that inspection to dinner.

You still name a real problem when it is real. Redirection is not pretending the saber-tooth is a berry bush. It is refusing to live in the story of the teeth after the danger has passed.

Close of Chapter 6

That is the incentive picture:

An incentive is anything that makes a behavior more likely or less likely next time.

Incentives run modern life, including this relationship.

Operant is what follows the action. Classical is what the person has come to mean when they walk in.

Fear outruns happiness. That is the -2.

Redirection is how you put most of your effort on the +1 without pretending teeth are imaginary.

You now know what pays and what costs. The next chapter is about when. Behavior is shaped in the present, but people live in

stories about what already happened and what might happen next. Chapter 7 is time travel: how you change this hour without waiting for a new personality.

Chapter 7 Time Travel

Bribery vs rewards

A reward follows a positive behavior so that behavior happens more. A bribe is the deal you announce first: do this and you get that. Same object can be either one. Timing and how obvious you make it are the difference.

You want the dishes in the dishwasher. A reward is noticing they did it and giving something that lands in their love language. A bribe is “I’ll get you _____ if you do the dishes.” Used once, that can start a new behavior. Used as the system, they learn the dishes are not worth doing. The prize is.

Overt gifts on a schedule become expected. Then you do not have a trained behavior. You have a vending machine. They will wait for the coin.

Bribes also teach the wrong lesson about the task itself. The message becomes: this only matters if there is something in it for me. That hollows out the thing you wanted — coming home on time, shoes on the rack, a kind sentence — until the prize is missing and the behavior vanishes with it.

Watch for dependence:

They will only do it if a reward is offered first.

They get agitated when no reward shows up, even when they had no reason to expect one.

They fish for praise or gifts whether the behavior happened or not.

The behavior never starts to stand on its own.

There is no sign they see any point in the thing except the payoff.

That is your test. Once in a while, withhold the reward and see whether the positive behavior continues. If it dies the first time the prize is late, you built a bribe. If it continues, the reward did its job and you can make it quieter.

Physical gifts should be rare. Most of the time the reward is the thing Chapter 2 already taught you: the right words, time, touch, help, notice. A gift can show up once in a while. If it is the usual currency, you are shopping for compliance.

Creating the present — asking while offering something good — sits closest to bribery. Keep the ask light and the prize from becoming the headline. Changing the present — noticing after the fact — is safer. Both still need this check.

The aim is not a person who works for treats. The aim is a positive behavior that becomes ordinary, with a reward that slowly becomes optional.

Changing the present

Operant conditioning is training. A behavior happens. Something follows. That result makes the behavior more likely or less likely next time. Positive redirection is how you name the behavior so you have something worth following with a good result.

Cover the floor first: needs, representational system, communication style, love language. Then you can train with happiness instead of fear.

Positive behavior and negative behavior

In any moment you can say one of two things:

“I would like my partner to do this positive behavior more often.”

“I would like my partner to do this negative behavior less often.”

That is the same as “I like that” and “I don’t like that.”

The same fact can be named either way. Operant conditioning needs a behavior you can follow with a result. Positive redirection is choosing the name that points at the positive behavior.

They come home late.

Negative behavior: “I don’t like that my partner comes home late.”

Positive behavior: “I would like my partner to come home earlier.”

They leave dishes in the sink.

Negative behavior: “I don’t like that my partner leaves dirty dishes in the sink.”

Positive behavior: “I would like my partner to put the dishes in the dishwasher after they use them.”

Every negative behavior has a positive-behavior version. Train the positive behavior.

Why you use positive redirection here

A negative result lasts longer than a compliment. The brain is built to remember the saber-tooth. Anger and disappointment are remembered longer and stronger because they are seen as a threat or fear. A casual compliment can pass through without sticking.

So you do not change the present with fear unless they crossed a real boundary or were unfaithful. If your goal is to make them afraid of you, you are building the wrong relationship. For everything else, find the positive behavior and follow it with a reward. Slow and consistent. You are not trying to create someone who only moves when a prize appears.

If the old criticism is still sitting there, Chapter 8 is how you go back for it.

The list

Keep a running list.

Positive behaviors you want more of.

Negative behaviors you want less of, rewritten as positive behaviors.

Come home late → arrive home on time.

Shoes in the walkway → shoes on the rack or outside.

Clothes on the floor → clothes in the hamper.

Dishes in the sink → dishes in the dishwasher.

Rate each item 1–10. Ten matters this month. One can wait.

Then write the reward that will follow the positive behavior. Use their love language, representational system, and communication style. Add that reward to the line.

When the positive behavior happens, give a reward in their love language. If something good happens and you skip the chance to notice it and reward it, the behavior does not lock in.

Two ways to use the list today

Creating the present

You pair an ask with a reward before the behavior. Only start when they are already in a decent mood. You mention the positive behavior, or you ask for it lightly, and offer the reward.

Pick one positive behavior.

Choose the reward that works for them.

While they are in a good state, make a passing reference or an indirect ask.

When they do it, give the reward.

Keep going until the positive behavior shows up without the reward having to lead.

Watch for bribery or dependence.

Once you have created the pairing you follow Changing the present to ensure the behavior continues.

Changing the present

You do not announce a deal. You watch for the positive behavior, or for the result of it, then you give the reward.

Pick the same positive behavior.

Choose the same kind of reward.

Observe until the behavior happens, or you see that it happened.

Give the reward.

Keep going until it is ordinary.

Watch for bribery or dependence.

Creating a behavior leads with asking for the behavior and offering the reward. Changing behaviors leads with noticing the positive, which is much harder than noticing the negative. Both are the same lesson: positive behavior, paired with a reward, enough times that the useful behavior becomes the easy one.

Twenty-one instances is our usual guess as to how many pairings it takes for a habit to form. Everyone is different. We generally want to see 21 pairings on different days over the course of 1–2 months. Consistency is key.

When this stalls

Old habits and a long record of nagging slow it down. If this positive behavior is the same thing you used to complain about, the thank-you has to compete with the old negative result. The method still works. It just may need the cleanup in Chapter 8 before you fight arguments from three years ago.

Chapter 8 Changing the Past

This chapter will sound like a trick the first time you hear it. We are going to talk about traveling back through your partner's timeline and changing what an old night means. Some clients lack confidence in that. They treat it like a story instead of a method.

So we start with a short stretch of science. Published, peer-reviewed work is the basis. Field work is the proof. Memory is rebuilt. Emotion changes what gets stored and what gets pulled back out. A later story can move the memory of the night.

These methods do work when you have confidence in them. The mini lessons are there to give you that. If you are not confident in the method, you will flinch when you try the training, and your partner will feel the flinch. Confidence is part of the tool. Then we teach the method.

Memory is Fickle

People do not replay the past. They rebuild it. What you say after an event gets mixed into what they think they saw. That is the misinformation effect, described in the work of Elizabeth Loftus. Change the story that follows the night, and the memory of the night moves.

A fight is not stored like a recording. It is stored like a story you both keep editing. The year-two sentence from the Words chapter is still available because nobody wrote a better ending over it. A false or sloppy version will also stick if you repeat it.

That is why Chapter 7 said you may have to clean the past before a new reward can beat an old negative memory. You are not inventing a time machine. You are traveling back in your

partner's timeline to change the past.

You already do this every day, every argument, every fight, every fond memory.

You are changing the narrative attached to the old scene so the next time it comes up it is a better version.

People's memories of an event can be easily influenced by later stories, explanations — and by the emotion attached to them.

Emotions & Memories

Emotion changes what we store and what we pull back out. How you felt when it happened matters. How you feel when you remember it matters too.

When we experience strong emotions, such as fear, excitement, or happiness, the amygdala — a region involved in emotional arousal — becomes more active. That activity helps lock the event into long-term memory, which is why charged moments stick harder than dull ones. That is why the fall on the camping trip outlasts the trees, and why a sharp sentence outlasts a quiet afternoon.

Recall is also biased by the mood you are in now. If you are already hurt or angry, the old scene comes back uglier than it was. The bad parts sharpen. The good parts fade. That is why a fight drags in the past under the worst light — worse than either of you would tell it on a decent day.

“Emotion can significantly impact memory, with more emotional events being better remembered.”

Two people can live the same night and keep two nights. One remembers the concert as great because they were happy. The

other remembers it as dull because they were anxious. Same room. Different file.

A more negative emotional state leads to a more negative recall of the past.

A more positive emotional state leads to a more positive recall of the past.

Then that version goes back into memory and hardens — with the new spin attached.

That loop is also the idea behind EMDR (Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing), a treatment used for trauma and PTSD. You bring the old scene up on purpose, pair it with a different state, and let it store again with less charge.

Past Experience

Past experiences affect the way we remember past events in a number of ways.

One way is schema formation. Schemas are mental structures that represent our knowledge and understanding of the world. They help us organize new information by fitting it into what we already know. When we encounter a new event, we try to fit it into those existing schemas, and that shapes how we remember it.

If you have had many positive experiences with dogs, you may carry a schema that “dogs are friendly and loyal.” A new dog may be remembered that way even if it was not. If you have had negative experiences with dogs, you may carry “dogs are aggressive and dangerous,” and that will color the next meeting too.

Another way is memory consolidation. New information starts in short-term memory. For it to move into long-term memory and be easier to retrieve, it has to be consolidated — strengthened and made more stable over time. Past experience gives that new information a context to attach to. If you already know a language, a new word in that language is easier to keep because it has a place to land.

The same pairing shows up in a relationship. Old experience is the context. The new night attaches to it.

A more positive emotional state coupled with past positive memories will cause a more positive recall of different past events.

Difference in Fact

“Let’s agree to disagree.”

“That’s not how I remember it.”

It is common for two people to recall the same event in different ways.

Different perspectives. People notice and remember what was relevant to them. Two witnesses to a crash: one keeps the crumpled metal, the other keeps the injuries. Same event. Different memory.

Different processing styles. Visual, auditory, and kinesthetic people do not store the same night the same way. One keeps what it looked like. One keeps what was said. One keeps what it felt like in the body. Both can be sincere and still not match.

Misinformation. Memory is not a perfect record. New information after the fact can get mixed in. A rumor heard later

can become part of what someone thinks they saw.

Memory is constructive. People rebuild the scene when they retrieve it, and they do not all rebuild it the same way.

How the event is presented later matters. Order, pictures, emotional language — all of that can move what gets remembered.

A more positive emotional state, coupled with past positive memories, coupled with presenting the memory with a slight change in your partner's view of what happened, can cause a more positive recall of different past events.

Reality is Plastic

Plasticity: the quality of being easily shaped or molded.

What do Buddhist monks, pathological liars, and hypnotists have in common? They each know of or utilize the plasticity of reality.

What we call reality is the mind processing input from the five senses. Thoughts, beliefs, and later experience can change that processing. The scene is not a fixed object. It is fluid enough to be moved by what we think, say, and do afterward. That is how a monk trains attention, how a liar sells a false night, and how a hypnotist changes what the room feels like — not by swapping the furniture, but by changing how the mind files what the senses brought in.

External factors matter. So do the words you attach after the fact. That is the opening this chapter has been building toward.

Changing the past for the worse

*“What the eyes see and the ears hear, the mind believes.” ~
Harry Houdini*

How to make yourself, have been, a worse partner in the past.
Tense is quite challenging in time travel.

An event happened.

You and your partner have a memory of the event.

You have a perspective and schema about the event.

Your partner has a perspective and schema about the event.

You believe the event was positive, or you use positive redirection to remember the better bits of it.

You do not use what this chapter teaches, and you end up here:

Your partner is in a negative emotional state

They are in a negative and uncomfortable environment

Relevant or similar negative memories get dragged in and argued over

The event from above comes back as worse than you remember. Your partner points at the ugly details.

When they are already negative, and old negative memories are in the room, their memory of that event moves. It starts to seem worse than it was.

Don't fight or argue. It is pointless. It puts a negative spin on past events and makes you now, having been, a worse partner in the past.

You have made yourself now. Have been in the past. A worse partner than you actually were. The smallest things up to the present pick up that spin. So does what you do next.

If the event happened while walking the dog, walking the dog becomes the stimulus. Negative feeling becomes the response. Next time they walk the dog, the body gets there first. Negative memories are stronger and last longer than positive ones. Classical conditioning takes hold faster than operant conditioning.

Go back and read that entire section until you are convinced that arguing and fighting is completely pointless and damaging to a relationship. There are some tips later on for handling arguments.

Changing the past for the better

“What the brain thinks the eyes saw, and the brain thinks the ears heard, the mind believes.” ~ The Author

How to make yourself, have been, a better partner in the past.

An event happened.

You and your partner have a memory of the event.

You have a perspective and schema about the event.

Your partner has a perspective and schema about the event.

You believe the event was positive, or you use positive redirection to remember the positive bits of the event or around it.

You observe or help create a scenario where:

Your partner is in a positive emotional state

They are in a positive and comfortable environment

Relevant or similar positive memories are brought up and discussed, by you.

The event is brought up as a positive event. You point out the positive details.

When your partner is in a positive emotional state and those related good memories are in the room, their memory of the event moves. It starts to seem better than it did.

You have made yourself now. Have been in the past. A better partner than you actually were in the past. The smallest things up to the present pick up that spin. So does what you do next.

If the event happened while walking the dog, walking the dog becomes the stimulus. Positive feeling becomes the response. Next time they walk the dog, the body gets there first. Positive memories are weaker and last a shorter time than negative ones. You will need more cycles of positive reinforcement to move a memory toward the good than it took to drag it toward the bad.

Yes, these methods are used in everything from advertising to jury work. PR firms and political advisors are, by nature, experts at reframing memories.

Liebeck v. McDonald's — the coffee was too hot and dangerous; McDonald's did lower the temperature.

The Tonya Harding case — her ex-husband and a bodyguard attacked Nancy Kerrigan to keep her from the 1994 Olympics.

Leonard v. Pepsico, Lewinsky and Clinton, Watergate, and the rest.

Chapter 9 Changing the Future

He who controls the past commands the future. He who commands the future conquers the past. ~George Orwell

Most of the future is the past plus the present. Clean up the past. Reward the useful behavior in the present. That shapes the future.

You can also implant a memory on a night that has not happened yet. You frontload. You put happiness in before the event occurs. You can even steal the tense:

“Remember how wonderful a time we will have had tonight?”

That is not a joke. It hands the brain a finished good memory and asks the evening to catch up.

Say the good version out loud before you leave, so the night starts inside a useful schema.

Preview it in their system: what it will look like, how it will sound, how it will feel.

Give the night a name if it needs one. “Thursday is our cheap date” is remembered easier than an unnamed evening.

Set the good end of the night while you are still planning the start: the walk after, the sit-down, the easy close.

Prime the boring parts so the good mood does not have to fight logistics — gas, reservation, food started.

If you mention a reward ahead of time, keep it quiet and in their love language. Watch out for bribery.

Do not narrate trouble into a night that has not happened. The mind will file the warning as part of the plan. Speak the evening you want them to remember.

Do the work on the past. Do the work on the present. And when you can, install the good version of a night before the night starts. The future is what that combination turns into.

Chapter 10 How to Change your Partner

The last four chapters were the engine. Incentive. Changing the present. Changing the past. Changing the future. This chapter is the set of tools you actually pick up.

Each heading is a small practice. Not a new theory. You are increasing the number of useful moments, making the bond easier to feel, and catching the day before it turns into a fight you then have to unwrite.

Inventing or Increasing Romantic Gestures

The smallest gesture

The smallest gesture can make a big difference. Reaching out to touch them, saying something kind, or asking a question politely all help strengthen the bond.

Increasing the gesture with “I love it when you”

“I love it when you take my hand in yours and give it a gentle squeeze. It’s a simple gesture, but it means the world to me. It makes me feel loved, supported, and connected to you.”

Creating the gesture with “Did you know that you”

“Did you know that you take my hand in yours when we are walking together? I love it when you take my hand in yours and give it a gentle squeeze. It’s a simple gesture, but it means the world to me. It makes me feel loved, supported, and connected to you.”

or

“I love it when you put your hand around my waist when we are walking. It’s almost like a subconscious gesture. It’s a simple gesture, but it means the world to me. It makes me feel loved, supported, and connected to you.”

Name the act. Mention the subconscious. The brain often accepts that it is already doing the thing, and then the thing starts to show up.

Skiping the poetry

These examples are mushy and overdrafted on purpose. If you are not the romantic-poetry type, use the short versions: “I love it when you take my hand.” “Did you know you do that when we walk?” That is enough.

Incentive and operant conditioning

That feedback creates a positive memory attached to the action. The action gets a reward, so it starts to repeat. Even if the action has not really been happening, naming it as if it has can start it happening.

How to increase the strength of your bond using science

Research shows when two people are in love and spend time with each other, their steps and heartbeats synch. In a study published in the journal *Psychological Science*, researchers found that couples who were in love had a tendency to walk in sync with each other, even when they were not holding hands. This phenomenon, known as “entrainment,” is thought to reflect the emotional connection and synchronization between the two

individuals.

A study published in the journal PNAS found that the heart rates of couples who were in love tended to become more synchronized over time. The researchers monitored the heart rates of couples who were watching a romantic movie together, and found that the heart rates of the individuals tended to become more similar as the movie progressed. This suggests that the emotional connection between couples can also affect their physiological responses, such as heart rate.

These studies show that when two people are in love and spend time together, their movements and physiological responses become more synchronized. This phenomenon reflects the emotional connection and bond between the individuals.

Intentionally Synchronize your Steps (Mirroring)

Synchronizing your steps with your partner is a fun and simple way to strengthen your bond and increase feelings of connection. When you intentionally synchronize your steps, you are bringing attention to the physical connection between you and your partner, which increases feelings of closeness and harmony.

Additionally, walking in sync has physiological benefits, reducing stress and increasing feelings of well-being. When we walk together with someone, our brain and body naturally respond to each other's movements, which creates a sense of mutual support and connection.

To synchronize your steps with your partner, start by paying attention to each other's movements as you walk. Gradually, adjust your own steps to match your partner's pace and rhythm. You may find that it takes some practice to get in sync, but with time and attention, you can create a natural and harmonious

rhythm together.

Remember, the key is to intentionally bring attention to the synchronization and to make it a conscious effort. By doing so, you can strengthen your bond and increase feelings of connection and harmony with your partner.

What becomes true is true. If you consciously walk in synch step with your partner your brain will feel more in synch with them. Over time this will happen subconsciously. Meaning what is true becomes true. Once it is true and you by default walk in synch with your partner, you can bring it up to them. Again the magic estimate is 21 times, not steps, 21 walks while synching your steps in order to get your subconscious to change.

How to increase the strength of your bond using science

When two people spend real time together, their bodies start to match. Research in Psychological Science found couples in love tend to walk in sync, even without holding hands. Work in PNAS found heart rates move closer while watching a film together. That matching is called entrainment. You can wait for it to happen naturally, or you can speed up the process and enhance your bond.

Walking in sync has physiological benefits. It can reduce stress and increase a sense of well-being. When you walk with someone, brain and body respond to each other's movement. That response feels like support and connection. The same idea sits under matched breath and matched heart rate. You bring attention to the match on purpose. Conscious first. Then it goes quiet and stays.

Synchronize your steps

Notice their pace and rhythm as you walk.

Gradually adjust your own steps to match.

Keep at it. It takes practice before it feels natural.

Keep your attention on the match. That attention is part of the tool.

What becomes true is true. Walk in sync on purpose and the brain starts to feel in sync. Do it long enough and it goes subconscious. Twenty-one walks is the usual guess. Not twenty-one steps. Twenty-one walks.

Then you can mention it. “Have you ever noticed that our steps sync up when we’re walking?” Mentioning it causes their subconscious to notice and perform the action more.

Synchronize your breathing

Sit or lie close enough to notice their breath.

Gradually match inhale and exhale. Slow to them, or let them slow to you.

Keep at it. It takes practice before it feels natural.

Keep your attention on the match. That attention is part of the tool.

What becomes true is true. Breathe in sync on purpose and the brain starts to feel in sync. Do it long enough and it goes subconscious. Twenty-one sessions is the usual guess. Not twenty-one breaths. Twenty-one sessions.

Then you can mention it. “Have you ever noticed we breathe together when we sit like this?” Mentioning it causes their

subconscious to notice and perform the action more.

Synchronize your heartbeat

If you aren't David Blaine or a monk, you probably currently aren't able to control your heart rate on command. Use breathing, which you can control. Your heart rate follows proximity and breath.

Get comfortable and close.

Gradually match breathing.

Notice your heart rate. Stay with it. It takes practice before it feels natural.

Keep your attention on the match. That attention is part of the tool.

What becomes true is true. Sit in sync on purpose and the brain starts to feel in sync. Do it long enough and it goes subconscious. Twenty-one sessions is the usual guess. Not twenty-one beats. Twenty-one sessions.

Then you can mention it. "Have you ever noticed how quiet it gets when we sit like this — your heart rate, mine?" Mentioning it causes their subconscious to notice and perform the action more.

A warning from experience

Do not synchronize your pee schedules on purpose or by accident. It is annoying.

Daily GPSing

Younger people do not unfold paper maps much. They follow a GPS. This section is how you become part of your partner's

metamap — the mental map of what things in the day mean. Coffee, keys, waking up, falling asleep. You want those moments to include you without a meeting.

Thoughts and habits run on those maps. If you are a usual mark on the map, they think of you when the stimulus shows up. That is not magic. It is association plus timing.

The subconscious is easier to reach when the conscious mind is quiet: first thing in the morning and just before sleep. Suggestions land better then. Morning and night routines use that window on purpose.

Morning routine

Good morning

A compliment

A positive forecast for the day

“Good morning, handsome. I hope you have a wonderful day.”

“Good morning, beautiful. I wish you a fantastic day.”

“Good morning, sunshine. I hope your day is as bright as you are.”

They should wake up to that. Same bed: say it when they first wake. Apart: send it so it is the first thing they see.

“Just one small positive thought in the morning can change your whole day.”

— Dalai Lama

Nighttime routine

Good night

A compliment

A wish that they sleep well

“Good night, my love. Sleep well and sweet dreams.”

“Good night, beautiful. I wish you a peaceful sleep.”

“Good night, sweetheart. Sleep well.”

Same idea, within a half hour of them drifting off. Same bed: say it before they fall asleep. Apart: send it so it is close to last.

These two bookends put you in a positive light at the open and the close of the day. That is how you get onto the map.

If you are not doing this, how much effort are you actually putting in? See reason #1 and #2 relationships fail: pay attention. If they never send or answer these, ask the same question of them.

#1 Communication (including contempt), #2 Attention (presence, affection, sex), #3 Money

Being the caring provider first thing in the morning

Coffee, keys, bag, phone, purse — the objects that start the day. Put them where they belong. Fill the pot. Set the cup out. Pack the lunch if that is the morning. That is care as acts of service, and it is also a pairing.

Those objects become the stimulus. The feeling of being looked after becomes the response. Classical conditioning: they reach for the keys and a good thought about you shows up with them. Do it enough mornings and the bag itself carries you.

This is not a speech. It is the thing being ready when they need it. Stress drops. The day starts with you already on the metamap.

Hide and Seek

Associate yourself with the things they lose — keys, phone, glasses — by being the person who helps find them. Problem solver, not magician.

If they often recover the missing thing when you are in the room, you get paired with the search. Looking for it becomes the stimulus. You, then the object, becomes the response. That is classical conditioning. Used clean, it is help. Used dirty, it is a trick.

Do not hide their things.

Do not move the keys and pretend you do not know.

Do not “lose” the phone so you can be the hero who finds it.

That is lying. It trains them to need you for a problem you invented. The Brief already told you these tools can be used to harm. This is that, with a key ring.

If you are doing that, stop. If they are doing that to you, name it. A partner who plants the crisis so they can rescue you is not a provider. They are running a game.

The honest version

Watch. When they are actually looking, help. Put things back in the same place. Be the person who appears when the search is real, not the person who staged the search.

Done that way, you still get the pairing: lost object, then you, then relief. You also get to keep your word. The morning provider section already put you on the metemap with coffee and keys in their spot. Hide and Seek is the same map. No theater.

If the only time they feel you care is when something is missing, you built a bond to chaos. Fix the place the keys live. Show up for the real search. Leave the rest.

Taking the temperature before the storm

Read the thermometer

Ask how they are — on a normal hour. Not because a look crossed their face. Not because the mood just changed. Not as a response to a mood.

“How are you feeling?”

“What’s up?”

“What are you thinking about?”

Asked when nothing is on fire, those questions teach both of you that words are allowed before anger. Asked because you spotted weather, they feel like an interrogation. The same sentence becomes a –2.

Learn from Chapter 3 how they want to be treated when they are already “moody.” Some people want space. Some want a sit. Guessing from a look and then poking is how you start the storm you claimed you were measuring.

Make the check a habit with no trigger attached. Then you already have the reading when the weather actually turns.

Unprompted compliments

This is not a save after you zoned out. It is a genuine compliment with no cue — no question, no fight, no look you are trying to fix. Eye contact. A true sentence. Random on purpose. That is what increases the romantic feeling and the bond.

“I was just thinking about how beautiful you are.”

“I was just thinking about how much I appreciate you.”

“Did you know you have the most beautiful eyes?”

Then stay there. That is presence.

The dark use

Do not use this to buy forgiveness for not listening.

Do not use it to dodge something you did.

Do not use a compliment as a smoke bomb so the last five minutes disappear.

Notes

“I’m sorry I was distracted thinking about how handsome you are — what were we talking about?” can be a clean reset if you were only lost for a second and you mean it. Used on purpose after you ignored them, or after you got caught, it is a trick. They will feel the dodge even if they take the line.

Better: pay attention. If you missed it, say you missed it, then ask them to repeat. The compliment is extra, not the eraser.

Application of an ‘Idol’

An idol here is your favorite actor or actress — the person you would want a hall pass for, the person you would give up everything for one night with.

You already have fantasies, feelings, and sometimes desire pointed at someone who is not in the room, however remote. This method is how you transfer that wasted heat to your partner instead of spending it on a third party.

Keep it private because of the danger of comparison.

What you do not do

Do not compare them out loud.

Do not expect them to become the idol.

Do not grade their face, body, or personality against a poster. Do not say, “You remind me of _____.”

That is how you install an impossible job and then punish them for not being someone else. It will offend them. It will also make you cruel when they are only themselves.

What the method actually is

You keep the link in your own head. When you look at your partner, you notice a trait that already pulls you — the smile, the walk, the voice — and you let the warmth you already have for the idol attach to this person in the room. You are aiming existing attraction at the one you are with, not shopping for a replacement.

Done that way, you get more affectionate and more respectful. The partner feels the increased desire without knowing the source. You also reclaim the misplaced affection, fantasy, and desire that was sitting on someone who is not in the room.

Why people call it dishonest

You are using a third person as fuel. They did not consent to be a stand-in. If the only way you want them is when they flicker as someone else, you are not with them. You are with a projection. That is the harm.

If you cannot look at them without the other face, stop. That is not a method. That is a leak.

Progress with caution. If you need a hall pass to want the person in front of you, the method is not the problem. The pairing is.

Positive words bring happiness

People like you more when you are happy. You like people more when they are happy. Humans like humans more when they are happy.

Positive words are one of the cheap ways to put that feeling in the room. Specific beats poetic. True beats a speech. “You handled that well” does more than “you’re fine.”

Words are remembered. Said often enough, they change the climate. Trust goes up because the mouth matches care. They feel seen instead of inspected. Respect has somewhere to land. The next hard sentence is easier to hear because the last ten were not teeth.

This is the positive side of the math from Chapter 6, spoken. It will not cancel a negative by itself. It will make the next negative rarer if you actually stop stacking those.

If this sounds repetitive, that is because it is. People skip the front of books, especially the ones who think they already

communicate. You know who you are. The background matters. Words install. You already saw that. Here you just point them at the person you live with.

Complaining, Whining, Nagging = Complimenting, Planning, Changing

Humans go to the problem first. Finding the threat is easy. It feels like control. It feels like you did something. Fixing the thing takes effort and risk, so a lot of people never get there. They name the issue, then they name it again, then they name it in a tighter voice.

That is complaining, then whining, then nagging. It is common in romantic pairs and in every other kind of pair. Left alone it turns into resentment. The other person stops hearing the content and only hears the tone.

A complaint is often a real need that never got said as a request. One person thinks the dishes belong in the washer every night. The other does them a few times a week. Nobody put the expectation on the table, so it leaks as “you never.” Say the need once, in plain language. Or use Changing the Present and follow the version you want with a reward. Repeating the same cut is nagging. Nagging trains them to go deaf.

Whining is the same content with a pitch that makes the body leave the room. Watch your tone. They will. You will.

The swap is not “never mention a problem.” The swap is where you put your weight after you see it.

Compliment what is already working so the week is not only inspections. Plan something you both get a vote on so the next hour has a point besides the grievance. Change the half that is actually yours — your timing, your voice, your piece of the

chore, the text you send before you are late. That is self-redirection. It is also the only part you can guarantee.

Planning together does a second job. It gives the pair something in front of them instead of only something behind them. Shared plans make memory. They also give the person who feels powerless a lever.

OK, I've stopped. They have not.

They will still dump things they cannot steer.

"Why can't we ever do what I want? It's always what you want."

"Why do you always work late? Can't you come home on time for once?"

Do not try the case. Name the need underneath, then hand them a piece they can control.

"You want more of a say in the week. Let's each pick one night."

"You want me home. I'll tell you before I'm late, and Thursday stays ours."

Sometimes you have to invent the lever. A calendar. Turns. A standing night. That is positive redirection plus a little control returned to the person who felt they had none. A counselor will dress it up. The move is the same.

If they are venting about the world

Heat, grocery lines, traffic, rude clerks, dead internet. None of that is the relationship and all of it can still wear you out if it becomes the evening.

Same rule. Aim them at a thing they can touch.

“The line is ugly. Want to go at 8 tomorrow, or order pickup?”

“Traffic is ugly. Different route this week, or a podcast in the car?”

You are not required to fix the highway. They have to carry their own locus of control. That is not a chapter in this book. It is still the job.

If the pattern is bigger than a redirect, use the person whose job it is. Relationship counselors for this. Lawyers for legal. Doctors for medical. Firefighters for fire.

Avoid Conflict by replacing a single word!

Swap but for and.

“But” erases the sentence in front of it. “I like your idea, but it could be improved” means they did not like the idea. The ear only keeps what followed the blade.

“And” keeps both halves in the room.

“I like your idea, and it gets better if we add this.”

“I hear you, and I need Thursday.” “That worked, and next time we leave at 8.”

You are not pretending there is no second point. You are refusing to delete the first one. That is enough to keep a lot of ordinary friction from turning into a trial.

It will not save a fight you already decided to win. It will change the ones that were only a bad conjunction.

Are we fighting

When the room gets loud, ask a small question in a flat voice.

“Are we fighting?”

“What are we fighting about?”

Not as a taunt. As a reading. A calm tone tells them you are not adding fuel. The second question forces a label. A lot of “fights” are hunger, a look, a leftover from Tuesday. Once it has a name, you can decide if it is worth the night.

If they say yes, you now have a subject. If they say no, you can stop performing a war that only one of you signed up for.

Are we fighting — NLP version

Sometimes the first question is not odd enough to interrupt the loop. You use a line that does not belong.

“Are we fighting about your blue car with the yellow door?”

The image is wrong on purpose. It stalls the part of the mind that is already writing closing arguments. Then you follow, same calm tone:

“Why are we fighting?”

That is the actual question. The car is only a speed bump.

Do not use the odd line to make them feel stupid. Do not use it to wipe their point off the table. If they were naming a real thing, you still have to answer the real thing after the stall.

Two tools. Same job. Get a label on the weather before you both spend the archive on it.

Recoding a fight

After a fight has already happened. What you do in the next quiet hour decides which version gets stored in memory.

Leave it raw and Chapter 8 has to work twice as hard. You already know the mechanism: emotion at recall writes the spin. Sit down still furious and you will rebuild the night uglier than it was. Sit down later, name your part, and the memory can move.

This is not a rematch. This is the debrief. Soldiers do it so the next contact is cleaner. You do it so year nine does not get a perfect recording of the worst ten minutes.

Do this after both of you can sit. Not in the spike. Not at 1 a.m. If one of you is still hot, you are not in the aftermath. You are in the fight. Wait for the pause.

The sequence

What did I feel? One or two words first, then a sentence. Angry. Small. Cornered. Left. Do not skip to what they did. If you cannot name the feeling, you will only name their crime.

What was my part? A real piece. Tone. Timing. The always/never. Walking out. You do not have to take their whole story. You take yours. “I raised my voice.” “I brought up your mother.” “I made it a character judgment.”

What did I hear you say? Play it back. “I heard that I don’t care about the week.” Then shut up long enough for them to correct the playback. Most fights are two different nights in one kitchen. This step is Difference in Fact, used on purpose.

What did I need that I did not ask for in a usable form? Not “you should have known.” The actual need: earlier notice, a hand,

ten minutes before we talk money, the dishes in the washer. If it was only a hint, it was not a request. Chapter 1 already told you that.

Is any of this an old trigger? Sometimes the volume is this evening. Sometimes it is a schema from years before they met you. One sentence is enough. “When the door slams I am twelve again.” You are not doing therapy on each other. You are labeling why the body went loud so the next time it happens you both recognize the weather.

What will I do different the next time this subject shows up? One behavior. Not a new personality. “I will ask for the pause before I speak.” “I will put the thing in the washer before you have to see it.” “I will not use always.”

How you talk while you do it

Calm voice. No audience. No phones as a shield. No stacking new charges onto the old night. You are leveling: same message in words, face, and body.

Validate the feeling even when you dispute the facts. “I get that you felt ignored. I do not agree that I don’t care. Here is what I was doing.” Both can be true.

Repair the sentence, not only the mood. “I said you never help. That was false.” The archive needs a contradictory entry or the insult stays canon.

What this is not

It is not who won.

It is not a full Chapter 8 rewrite of childhood.

It is not a speech about their soul.

It is not optional if you used a horseman.

Twenty minutes is enough. An hour is a courtroom. Stop when you have a feeling, a part, a playback, a need, and one next behavior.

Then leave the subject. Touch if that is their language. Food. Sleep. Do not hold a performance review of the debrief.

You are writing a better version of the night before it hardens. That is Changing the Past on a six-hour delay.

Pause

The rule is still: do not fight. A pause is how you keep that rule when you are already emotional.

Flooded means the feeling has the wheel. Ears gone. Mouth only good for a sentence you will hear again in year nine. Chapter 8 already told you that argument makes you, have been, a worse partner. You do not need a better fight. You need an exit before the file updates.

Agree on it before you need it. One word. An agreed-upon time.

“Pause. Twenty minutes.”

Then take the time. Walk. Water. Breath. Do not use the break to load new charges. Then return.

A pause with no return is walking out. A return with no pause is how both of you spend the tongue.

If they call it, let them have it. Do not follow them with the rest of the speech. The speech is the fight. You already decided not to have that.

Pause.

Chapter 11 — The number-one way to change and maintain your relationship

This applies from before you meet someone to the fiftieth anniversary and after.

The tools in this book are how. This chapter is whether you will run them every day or treat them like a weekend seminar.

Maintain a positive attitude toward your relationship

Belief is the load-bearing wall. When you are certain the pair is worth the work, you meet a hard week as a problem to solve. When you are already half-out, the same week is evidence. You will use the same mouth either way. One version builds. The other files a brief for the exit.

Confidence here is not cheerfulness. It is deciding, in advance, that you will stay on the tools when it is boring.

The slightest doubt will bring the whole thing down

Beliefs sit on repetition and on what you allow in. A small doubt does not stay small. “Are they faithful?” asked once as a real question is data. “Are they faithful?” rehearsed all week is a story you are installing. The story starts to write the room: the late text, the laugh with someone else, the quiet hour. You will find proof. That is how schemas work. You already read that chapter.

What is a belief?

“A belief is just something we tell ourselves over and over again.” ~ Unknown

You are running a loop. Repeat a useful line and it gets easier to act as if it is true. Repeat “this is already dead” and you will perform the funeral. Chapter 1’s inner narrator and the Words chapter are the same machine pointed inward and then at them.

Watch the sentence you are rehearsing. If it is not a sentence you would allow out loud about them, do not grow it in private either.

The slightest negative thought can take root

One ugly line, watered daily, becomes the climate. Resentment. Bitterness. A mouth that only inspects. You do not need a crisis. You need a thought you declined to pull.

Compliment your partner behind their back

Say the good thing when they are not in the room. To a friend. To family. To a coworker who only knows them as a name.

That does two jobs. It trains your own mouth. It also travels. People repeat what they hear. They will feel it when it gets back to them, and they will feel the opposite if the only stories you tell on them are complaints.

Negative talk behind their back is a slow leak. If they hear it, you earned the hit. If they never hear it, you still trained yourself to see them as a problem you narrate for an audience.

H2LP already taught this on anybody. Here you point it at one person and you do not break it when you are annoyed.

Will, focus, commitment, and determination

Believe, every hour you are in this, that the relationship can work — not as a mood, as a decision. Will. Focus. Determination. No theatrical doubt performed for sympathy.

Do not let the cheap negative sit when you are talking:

with your partner

about your partner

about the relationship

with yourself

Never let a single negative thought take root as the official story. You will still have bad hours. You do not have to make them the belief.

Be unreasonably certain you are building something that lasts, and be able to see it: ordinary years, not a montage. Open, honest communication plus that stance will do more than a new trick from Chapter 10.

“Be careful of your thoughts, for your thoughts become your words. Be careful of your words, for your words become your actions. Be careful of your actions, for your actions become your habits. Be careful of your habits, for your habits become your character. Be careful of your character, for your character becomes your destiny.” ~ often attributed to Frank Outlaw; commonly called a Chinese proverb

That is the book in one stack. Thought. Word. Act. Habit. Character. Destiny of the pair.

You do not dabble in a relationship and then act surprised when it dies of neglect. You run the floor: yourself first, the

message that arrives, the incentive that pays the useful behavior, the past cleaned, the future loaded, the small daily tools, the repair you go first on.

That is the number-one way. The rest of the book is how you spend it.